

Editorial

Gaming Can Heal

IN SEPTEMBER 2005, a news item appeared on the Net about a study conducted by Dr Bryan Raudenbush of the Wheeling Jesuit University in the US, indicating that video games can be used effectively to distract from pain, if not actually relieve it. Raudenbush's study, called *Effects of Video Game Play on Pain Threshold and Tolerance*, examined the psychological effect of games on pain sufferers. Six genres of games—action, puzzle, arcade, fighting, sport, and boxing—were used in the study, where participants played games of each type for five minutes for practice, then a longer session for 10 minutes. Raudenbush concluded that playing games increased players' pulses, as well as their tolerance for pain.

Some of us might have read that news bit and rubbished it as yet another piece of quirky research—by, possibly, a gaming evangelist—or even as an industry-sponsored study determined to project the positive effects of gaming. So much has been written about the ill-effects—the negative psychological and physiological impact of games — on kids, that we look with suspicion upon any positive news on this front.

But it turns out that a piece of news from Reuters corroborates Dr Raudenbush's study. It highlights the use of video games to help sick children manage pain and anxiety during hospital stays. Nine-year-old Ethan Myers was declared brain dead as a result of a car accident in 2002. Doctors had said at the time that Ethan would never again eat on his own, walk or talk.

Now, due to neuro-feedback training on the CyberLearning Technology LLC system, often used to play car racing video games, Myers has caught up with his peers in school, and can even read out a speech to a large group of students. He has also re-learned to walk, and his memory now allows him to remember peoples' names. More importantly, Myers can now also fully open his right hand, which paralysis had curled closed. "In the last year, we've seen the Ethan we knew before the accident," says Howard Myers, the teenager's happy father.

CyberLearning's SMART BrainGames system, which was used by Myers, targets symptoms arising from brain injuries, attention-deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD) and learning disabilities.

Neuro-feedback treatment has been around for decades, but its use of video games is a new development that tries to capitalise on the younger generation's fascination with animation and electronics to sweeten often frightening, lengthy and tedious medical treatments. Some schools in the US are even using



Deepak Ajwani Associate Editor

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video games to combat obesity and have made it part of their curriculum.

All this research, I'm sure, has brought cheer to gaming enthusiasts—and also the gaming industry. Young gamers will now cite this research to their parents and justify their never-ending gaming sessions and the endless hours spent in front of the computer or gaming consoles. Sceptics, however, still question the efficacy and cost rationale behind this treatment. Despite the demonstrated benefits of neuro-feedback, paediatrics demand better-designed studies to help parents of children with ADHD make informed decisions.

It all does seem intuitive, though. Laughter is the best medicine because it's a stress buster—it's a momentary burst of release, so to speak. The gaming experience is similar: it's a brief period of escapism, of total release from the shackles of the world; it's "re-creation" in the true sense. And that is, naturally, good for you.

editor@thinkdigit.com